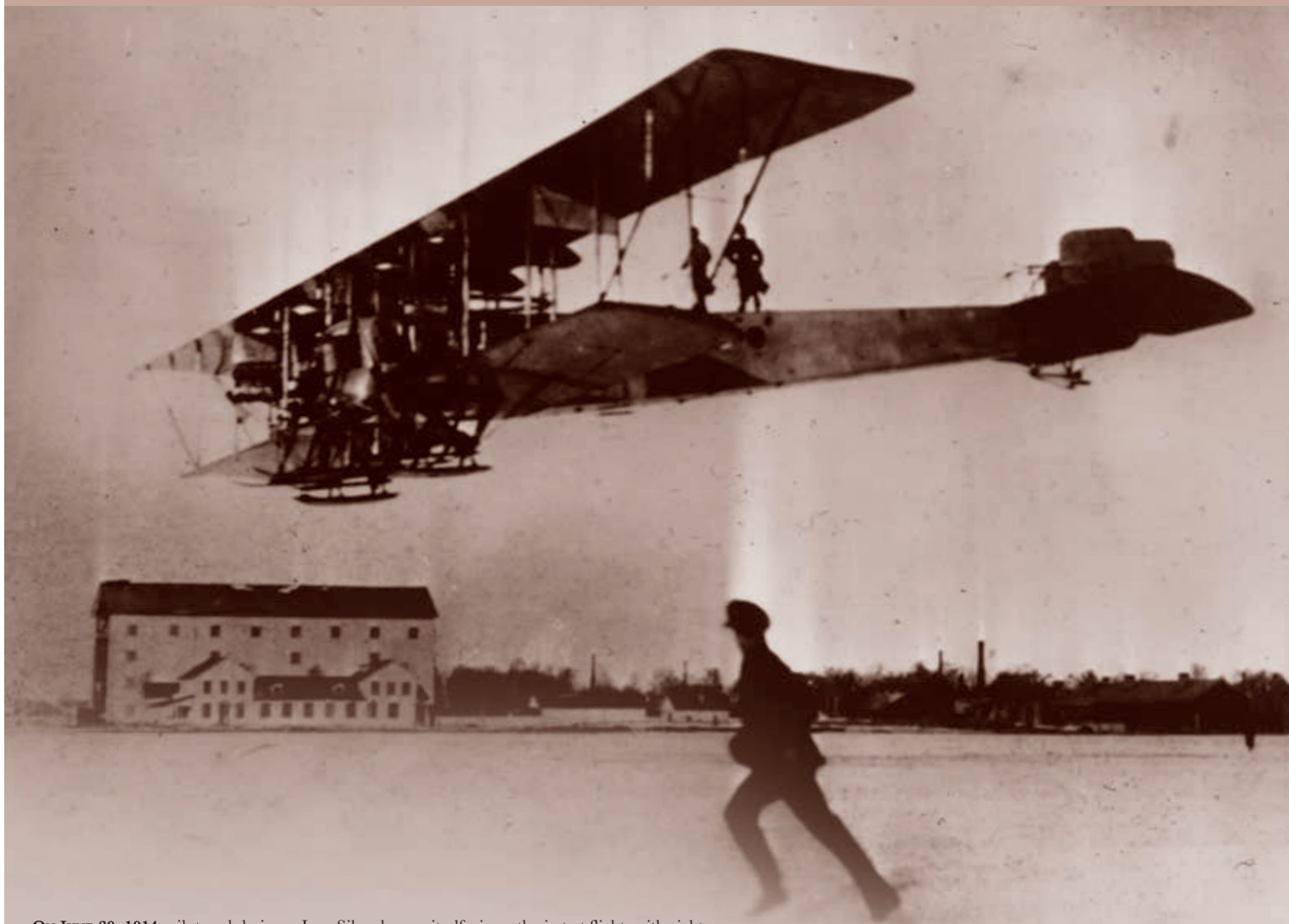


THE SPECTACULAR FLIGHT OF THE IL'YA MUROMETS



ON JUNE 30, 1914, pilot and designer Igor Sikorsky took off on one of the most spectacular flights of the prewar, pioneering era of aviation. In his four-engined Il'ya Muromets, Sikorsky intended to fly from St. Petersburg over the forests and swamps of northern Russia to Kiev and back – a round trip of 1,600 miles (2,600km).

Working for his wealthy patron Mikhail Shidlovski at the Russo-Baltic Wagon Works in St. Petersburg, Sikorsky had first designed a four-engined airplane, the Grand, in 1913. With a wingspan of 88ft 7in (31m), it was a giant aircraft for its day. Foreign aviation experts, convinced the monster plane would never fly, dubbed it the “Petersburg Duck.” But in May 1913, fly it did, and the “Duck” soon proved

itself airworthy in test flights with eight passengers aboard.

In October 1913, Sikorsky built the even larger Il'ya Muromets. Its wingspan was 105ft (37m), its fuselage was 77ft (27m) long, and fully loaded it weighed over 12,000lb (5,400kg). Even with four 100hp engines driving four tractor propellers, this was a lot of weight to get off the ground. The airplane could carry 16 people, including the crew, and by the spartan standards of the day, offered remarkable comfort. It had a heated passenger cabin with electric lights powered by a wind-driven generator, a bedroom, and the first airborne toilet. There was a balcony at the front, allowing passengers spectacular aerial views, and (for the brave) an observation platform on the rear fuselage.

“Aeronautics was neither
an industry nor a science.
It was a miracle.”

IGOR SIKORSKY

The 1914 flight of the Il'ya Muromets was intended to demonstrate beyond any doubt that Sikorsky had created a truly practical large aircraft. It took off at first light on June 30 carrying Sikorsky, three other crew, and substantial supplies of spare parts, food, and fuel. They were going to fly over a wilderness with no accompanying trains or cars.

After an uneventful eight hours, the aircraft made its first stop at a refueling site at Orsha. The next leg of the journey, to Kiev, was, by contrast, dangerously exciting. An engine caught fire and two of the crew had to climb onto the wing to beat out the flames with their coats. Sikorsky made an emergency landing for repairs. Taking off the following morning, he soon ran into rain and low cloud. Turbulent air currents pitched the giant aircraft around, at one point throwing it into a spin